

Interviewer: It's only for our transcriptions and note taking naman. How old are you po?

Speaker: I'm [56-60] years old.

Interviewer: Well, actually, this is not necessary. I was about to ask how long you've been together with your wife, but she mentioned [26-30] years na po kayo.

Speaker: Yes, we're turning [26-30]. But since marriage. But we've known each other for.. Sorry. Plus, you just add, say, [6-10] years. 'Yun, so we've known each other for..

Interviewer: [1-5]?

Speaker: If my math is correct, so that will be [26-30] plus [6-10].

Interviewer: [31-35] years po.

Speaker: Yeah, [31-35], yes.

Interviewer: She mentioned that you have children. Well, just [1-5], 'no.

Speaker: Oo. Right.

Interviewer: I'll just go straight into it po. Can you tell me about your love story?

Speaker: I'm sorry, yeah, I didn't hear you clearly.

Interviewer: Can you tell me about your love story po?

Speaker: My love story. All right. Okay. We were actually.. We met in the church, and we go to church together. And then since I was involved in the youth ministry, so she got involved as well. And then, of course, we started with... Like.. We have common friends. And then we were not... We started not really dating, like, exclusive. It's more of a... Like a group, because we have common friends nga. And we have a common... In our church, because we have a common [occupation]. So we are being guided by a [occupation]. We call it a [occupation]. And then, of course, you cannot avoid when you are in a... Like in a youth ministry. So you get to talk about who is your... Who you get attracted to, or kung may crush ka man, ganito ganito. So may mga boys group, may mga girls group. And then I wasn't really that straightforward to her at first.

Speaker: And I think we only got close when I got involved in this.. When I started working. And then that company is looking for an [occupation]. So I thought of her, kasi I know that she's an [college course] graduate. So tinanong ko siya if she's interested. And then, yes, so she's interested. And then that's the time that we are able to... I mean, get close, get to know. So hinahatid ko siya ganito ganito. And then... 'yun, doon nagstart. Yung a deeper sense of a ...Actually, we started as friends. And then, of course, na develop na 'yun. And after that, we start dating. And then naging exclusive kami all of a sudden. Kasi noon, hindi naman uso yung ano, yung, like today ano, na you're gonna get the consent of the parents if I can pursue or court their daughter. Noon, basta nagda-date kayo, 'yun na 'yun. But of course, we started to pray for each one. We committed to ask the Lord if he's going to direct us into a more serious relationship. So it started there. And then, of course, when... So nagbago na rin kami ng career. She went into [occupation] while I went into a.. I got involved in a company. More of a corporate. And then we continuously, of course, with that exclusive relationship, I get to bring her to her office, we eat out, and then I get to visit her. 'Yun. And it went on.

Speaker: And in fact, in the course of that, we haven't really discussed about settling down. Kasi very idealistic kami noon. We agree na we're not going to settle down yet because we need to establish.. We need to establish our career. You know? And we wanted to, in fact, before we even settled down, we tried to buy a property. Just to prepare us for.. when we get married, at least meron na kaming property. But.. Ayun. So, short of it, it didn't push through. But we are able to finally settle down after [6-10] years. Yes. So long-term engagement ang nangyari sa amin. So hindi talaga dumating yung point na, "okay by this time, we're going to get married." Walang ganon. It just happened. So ayun, it started there. Doon nag start 'yun. No fancy things about... Kasi nga mahaba yung relationship and naging exclusive kami kaagad. So therefore, in fact, sa church nga, one of the, we call them the... Aming mga [occupation] na don't get exclusive to get involved yet because you're still young, ganito ganito. But for us deep down, kami na sa isa't isa during that time. And we no longer look for any other relationship.

Speaker: So that's how it started until I proposed to her after [6-10] years. And then I think it's about time for us to settle down. Kasi I think that is more than long enough for us to determine whether we're going to push through with this relationship. And the answer was clear that we will have this as a commitment, not only for each one, kasi we were taught to really.. When we get into our relationship, there's got to be a commitment to it. So not only, of course, what drives us is because we are assured that I love her and she loves me. Of course, that's the basis of our relationship. And then from there, doon na kami nagstart magplan. So 'yun na.

Interviewer: Wow, very malaman po 'yung the answer. You mentioned that you started out as friends and then you got closer when you started working. And then medyo long road po 'yung for [6-10] years 'no before marriage. And then, it just.. Even if you said that it just happened, parang there was a lot of work that you put into it.. Buying property, becoming workmates po. Ganoon po.

Speaker: Yeah.

Interviewer: [Participant], how would you compare the quality of your relationship compared to that of your friends' relationships?

Speaker: Meaning as.. as a friend?

Interviewer: Compared to your peers po.

Speaker: Ah, our peers. Ah, okay. Yung friendship, you mean?

Interviewer: The quality of your relationship po compared to the peers.

Speaker: Yes.

Interviewer: Yes.

Speaker: Compared to the peers...I just wanted to make clear kung I got it right. Compared to our peers with their relationship.

Interviewer: Yes po.

Speaker: All right. Okay, how do I... Kasi it's.. Every relationship has a uniqueness of its own. In fact, we don't really try to compare with others because we have our own... First, we have our own mind and our own... Yes, thinking of how we treat each other, how we value each other. And of course, I think there is

a semblance with others. Kasi we have peers, we have close friends. We also exchange notes in terms of the relationship on how things ought to be and not should be. 'Yung mga ganoon. But in terms of comparison, kasi iba iba naman tayo ng experiences. And.. So that's why it's... I mean, in my opinion, it's not really fair to compare us with the others. Kasi they're also going through a different life journey of their own. Like us. Iba rin yung background namin.

Speaker: What I really cherish and value is that yung family and my family, at least yung kanyang siblings, are also close to each other. Not really close close, but it's beyond acquaintance. The in-laws. Kasi she.. she's the only child that remained here in the [Country]. All her siblings now went abroad. And my siblings are here. They're based here. And whenever we have a get-together, kami yung center point. So we gather in our house. So, yung mga kapatid ko atsaka yung siblings niya actually know each other. So that's one thing that we really value. 'Yung.. Of course, my parents were... Mas nauna kasing namatay yung parents ko. Compare.. Unlike her parents, still alive. She's, I think, [91-95] years old. They didn't really have the chance to be close to each other. Unlike our brothers and sisters, our siblings. So when we plan together, when they are around, we'll make sure na kasama lahat. Like one big family. And I think that is one thing that I can really share. That I would say I'm proud of. Dahil magkakakilala kami. Mga kapatid ko tsaka mga kapatid niya. But not so much on the parents' side.

Speaker: And also, when comparing with the others, I'm having this difficulty in really comparing. Because what we believe and I believe is that in relationship, yes, you grow your relationship in the way that the Lord enabled you. So of course, we have our own struggles. Other couples have their own struggles. And that's why it's also healthy for us to share that with others. Not for the sake of comparing. But at least, mayroon kaming benchmark in terms of how our relationship should grow. One thing about our relationship is that we'll make sure that it is based on a Godly perspective. Biblical perspective. Because everything is written there about marriage. And so we work on it. I'm not saying na that we are good at it. We're still a work in progress. But at least we have a common denominator. And that is God himself. And that is how I value our relationship. I'm sorry. I hope I answered the intention of the question. Kaya lang kasi the question is, how do we compare.. How can I compare with others?

Interviewer: Some of my questions have to do with comparison po talaga. Sorry.

Speaker: I see. Alright. So we don't really dwell so much on "buti si ganito, ganiyan sila" yung mga ganoon ba. Or may mga instances wherein pagka mayroon kaming.. Say, concern or issues. We don't really think of papaano kaya nire-resolve 'yung issue nila ganito, 'yung ganitong couple na we know. We don't really dwell on that. We focus on our relationship. And if there's gonna be anything good out of it, then we share it.

Interviewer: I see po.

Speaker: If there's going to be any struggle through it, we also get to share it for as long as it benefits the others. So.. So, sa ganoon lang.

Interviewer: The next question also somewhat has to do with comparison. But do let me know if this is something that you're not really okay with answering. Can I also ask how many romantic partners you've had in the past?

Speaker: All right. Romantic partner. More of a ano... I would say not to the level of I would say.. 'Yung naging boyfriend or girlfriend. Yes, I think I have [1-5]. But it didn't really get into that series. It's more of

a yes, that's beyond friendship, I know. But of course, as you go along with that, you're gonna determine whether kung talagang it's worth pursuing. So, ako kasi, if it's not worth pursuing, I will not waste that person's time. So yes, I have, but it's very short ano lang.. Relationship. It didn't last. And the intention, I wasn't able to really establish my intent on that. So I would say very shallow.

Interviewer: I see po.

Speaker: It's not really a romantic thing. But started with friendship. Ganoon lang.

Interviewer: I was going to ask how would you compare the quality of your marriage compared to your previous relationships?

Speaker: Ah, I see. So there's really nothing to compare. It did not progress. In as much.. Not really in as much as I wanted it. Hindi talaga ano 'e.. But I was so young. I think I was only in college then. Yeah, college na ako noon. A clean freshman. But it didn't last. But the girl, of course, still trying to clarify, "Oh, what happened?" ganiyan, ganito. Alam mo 'yun? I was that guy, I.. perhaps, not that serious. Alam mo 'yun? Just to date. Ganoon. And that's it. Marami kasi akong ideals.. Very idealistic ako, I would say. Na I don't want to get into this unless I finish my schooling, ganiyan, ganito. So very idealistic. And so it did not progress until I met [partner].

Interviewer: You mentioned po kanina that something you value is as center in God in the Bible. So for you, what makes a relationship high quality po? If you feel like that trying to figures into my next question.

Speaker: High quality.. Yes. I would say, it is not perfect, of course. But there's still some level that you wanted to reach or to pursue. If you may call it quality. Kasi along the way, you can experience struggle because you are into a relationship. You have to.. There's a lot of things that you actually did not plan. But it's here that you have to face. That you have to, like, if there are conflicts that needs to be resolved, you cannot get away with it. But the underlying, I would say, quality is that whenever there are issues or problems, we are able to go through it together. I'm not saying that we resolve it completely. But the important thing is we are together into it.

Speaker: I know many couples approach it differently. Sa amin kasi, I would say we started, I would say, right in the right footing. Kasi we underwent, I think, [1-5] [occupation] before we even settled down. These are the volunteer [occupation] that we know, like pastors, they are couples as well. And who wanted to give us an advice. We went through a process pa 'nung like our.. 'Yung family tree. So we went as far as that. And then we'll see if there's going to be anything that may compromise when we build our own family. But, of course, maybe a basis 'yung ano..

Speaker: But what is important is that I would say our relationship is that in that level of quality that we desire or even wanted to pursue is that we are privileged to know the things that a couple should know early on. And I think it helped us through that [6-10] years of engagement to really sort things out. I'm not saying na we learned it all. But at least we're able to process it. So once it's there na, halimbawa ito, late din kami nagkaroon ng child. We struggle through it. And, of course, there are friends who are praying with us. And 'yung quality of that relationship, that marriage, I believe it's there. Because we're not alone. We have a community that help us go through this journey, especially when we are in struggle.

Speaker: And then after that, pagka narating mo na 'yung isang, say, season of your life, of course, we are [26-30] or going [26-30] years. We believe na marami parin kaming haharapin. And what we have learned in the past helps us pursue further. We do not know if it's going to be harder but definitely there are victories. There are successes. And that is what we really treasure. So pagka humaharap kami.. Say, issues of life sa aming dalawa or extended family, lahat-lahat na, we tend to recall on how the Lord has given us the strength, even yung how he has sustained us through the years. It's the same God who will sustain us in the coming years that we do not know how will it be. It really requires, yes, 'diba in a marriage, ang main purpose mo, why you married a person is because you love the person. But kami, it's beyond that. It is the person that the Lord intended for us to be or to live together as one for the rest of our lives.

Speaker: And for the remainder of that journey, it depends on God really. So 'yun, I would say that's the quality of where we are right now. Again, I'm saying it's not perfect, but one thing is good. We have a perfect God who bind us together as one. Kasi sa mata ni God, who instituted marriage, isa lang siya 'e. I mean, kaming dalawa, sa mata ni God, isa lang kami. We are one. We are not individual. We are one in his eyes. So therefore, if we are one, regardless of what we go through, we are still together. Hindi naman to the point na, okay, just for the sake of being together, no, it's a life living together. And then whatever life brings, kami paring dalawa. So, 'yun yung essence of till death was part. If you know about it, in your vows, 'diba? 'Yun na ibig sabihin. So, only death can really separate us.

Interviewer: So, you would say po na high quality relationships are able to stand the test of time, of challenges, and trusting all of that in the Lord.

Interviewer: What would make a relationship low quality naman po?

Speaker: Okay. Low quality. If I would say.. Paano nga ba? To answer that, I need to put myself out of it. Kasi I would say our relationship is a good quality. But I would say because of 'yung pagiging individual nila.. 'Yung pagiging selfish, 'yung couple na kayo, and yet ang tingin mo sa sarili mo is ano ka parin, you are on your own. So, I'm not saying it is really that bad, but it is also being used as an excuse for you not to be together. Like for instance, ofcourse kami, I would cite an example. We have different likes in terms of sports. Ako, I love to play golf, siya ayaw niya kasi mahirap daw. But that's fine.

Speaker: Before, I used to go with friends. Parang alam mo, hindi ko narin na-enjoy 'e. Because I would rather pursue a sports that we can do together, rather than on my own. I think a relationship, cinite ko 'yun as an example, is because there are situations wherein the relationship is being affected. And I would say that it becomes low quality. If you still go on with your activities, as if that you are single. But in fact, iba na 'e. Iba na 'yung ano mo, yung commitment mo, iba narin priorities mo sa buhay. So, therefore, it has to change. But if it doesn't change, then I think that brings affect in terms of quality of relationship in your marriage.

Interviewer: Parang counting for the other 'din po in your life decision.

Speaker: Ah, yes, I would say that.

Interviewer: For you po, what are the most important things in a relationship?

Speaker: The most important things in a relationship. I tend to go back on how God sees it. The most important thing in a relationship is that, like me as a husband, is to love her. 'Yun. Because it is very

important for a woman to be assured that he is really loved. Now, in terms of a wife naman, the most important thing is to respect the husband. Again, that is in a biblical standpoint. Syempre kasama nadoon 'yung love. But it is very important for the husband to be respected. So, therefore, and that is the most important.

Speaker: And another thing is the most important in a relationship is, remember, in a relationship, we are not.. the involvement is not only the two of us. It involves three beings, me, [partner], and God. And that is why we always cite this as an example, or as a diagram. Wherein, in a relationship, in a marriage, is a triangle? Triangle. So, ako sa kabilang side, siya 'yung kabila and God is in the middle. The more that we draw closer to God, individually, me, my relationship to God, and [partner], her relationship to God, the more we get closer to each other. Now, halimbawa if I walk away to my God, not following what the Lord is intended for me to do, like a husband to [partner], then we fall apart.

Speaker: So, for me, for us, I believe [partner] also stands by this, is the most important in a relationship is God himself, because he is the source of the relationship. And then what God mandated for me and for her, and for me, is to love her, unconditionally, regardless ano pa siya magiging when she gets old, and in the same way that she respects me. 'Yun.

Interviewer: Most important for God himself 'no, and it's not just you and [partner] in the marriage.

Speaker: Yes.

Interviewer: We've been talking about your love story po and the things important to your love, so I'd like to ask po, for you, what is love?

Speaker: Wow. Love is everything that one could ever desire in life, because without love, there's no life. Love is, of course, clear manifestation or definition of love is God himself. Malinaw sa scripture that God is love. So, without God, there will be no love. So that's how I defined it. Since God is love, it's the source of life itself. Without love, there is no life. And that's the reason why we are here, is because of how God has manifest himself, that he is a loving God. He is also a just God. Kasi pagka hindi mo siya sinunod, syempre you will suffer the consequences. But again, that is love for me. Love is everything that anyone could ever desire in this life. And once you are there, or you have love, we have the love of God, you have everything that this life could offer.

Interviewer: How do you know po that your partner loves you, that your wife loves you po?

Speaker: Ah, yes, damang-dama ko 'yun. Not only because ano siya e, mas expressive siya kasi kaysa sa akin. I think that's normal for a guy. But of course, I also..Vine-verbalize. But there is this love language that we have. Like, yung love language ko ay when she gives me something that I really like, like food. Because I'm a foodie guy. We just don't eat out. She makes it herself. And 'yung effort in everything, doing that and thinking what to cook or what to serve, doon, damang-dama ko 'yun. It's not because of food itself that it tastes good. By the way, she is a good cook. Pero 'yung all the effort that she poured out on that is I have no doubt at all of her love. 'Yan 'yun. Of course, one aspect lang 'yun. 'Yung food.

Speaker: But of course, men like me and my age may mga have preferences na rin ako. Of course, malinaw kay [partner] 'yun. Pagka-ayaw ko, hindi na niya pipilitin. Because she already knows na ayaw ko. Pero pagka, if there are things that I like, but I don't want to pursue, but she knows that I like it. For instance, I like to buy this, but it's not worth the money that I am gonna to spend. You know what she

will do? She's gonna buy it for me. Doon pa lang, damang-dama ko na. No, she doesn't have to do that. Kahit sinabi ko, if I have money, I will not buy that. But I like it. Kaya lang parang ano, for.. Para sa kanya, ang thinking niya, if you like it, you really have to spend for it. Hindi ako ganoon. Madali lang ako ma... I can easily be satisfied basta na-appreciate ko lang 'yan. Not necessarily owning it. But I just like it. And then before you know it, 'yan, binili na pala niya, ganon. Because she knows that I like it. So 'yun, I just cite an example.

Speaker: But there are so many instances that I can prove that she loves me. More importantly, pagka may ginagawa akong mali, she could easily forgive me. 'Yan. 'Yun, I can just cite those instances.

Interviewer: That's lovely po. How important is love in a relationship po?

Speaker: Yes, that is how important love is. That's the reason why you are in a relationship because of love. Apart from love, there's no reason for you to be together. That's the reason why you are together because you have that love to give. I have that love to give to share it. And vice versa. Ganoon din. Kasi, if you don't have it, there's nothing to give. But since you have it and you wanted to give it wholeheartedly to the person that you really love, no matter what, ano 'e.. Nandoon 'e. it's so hard to explain. But without that sense of love, parang you just coexist. Which is sad. Yes, you can enjoy doing things together, watching people together, enjoy some stuff. But if there's no love underneath all of those, it doesn't make any sense. You just coexist.

Speaker: So that's how important. You can actually sense it down na kahit you don't talk about anything, just the mere fact that you are present. Present ka lang and you are together. And you are at home. That's it. You have everything you need. It doesn't matter whether marami kang gamit o wala. It doesn't matter at all. The important is the person. The person that you live with, that you enjoy and love living together with.

Interviewer: Wow. That's very insightful. What is the point if there's no love.

Interviewer: You shared some insights din po earlier about how high quality relationships could stand the test of challenges. So I'm curious to know what would you say are the challenges in your relationship?

Speaker: You want me to cite an example of a challenge that we face?

Interviewer: If it's alright po.

Speaker: Ah, yes. Okay. Backtracking. Like in our first year of marriage, of course, we don't intend to have a child. Pero after second year or third year, that's where we plan to have one, but it didn't come. So we struggled through it. And we even come to the point where, yes, of course, we have ourselves checked. Actually, both of us have a problem. And in fact, it went to the point where in, it's almost impossible for us to have a child. So, of course, we pray hard. We seek, we sought the Lord on that. If it is His will for us not to have one, it came to the point na that's fine. The most important is we have each other. Para sa akin kasi ano, sa akin big deal 'yun. So we struggle through it. We fight for it many times.

Speaker: But it came to the point na where in, my boss knows a person, a woman, who is bearing a child out of wedlock. And my boss wanted to help me if [partner] and I would be willing to adopt. So we have the first refusal. And we prayed hard if it's really will. Then you know what happened? I think that was September because we need to tell that lady or that parent or that mom, the mother, if we are really

willing to go through the process of adoption, that was September. And we really prayed. And come October, she got pregnant. And after seven and a half years, at the point where in, we are about to adopt. So when she got pregnant, it's a celebration.

Interviewer: That's amazing.

Speaker: So we went through that test of, I would say, I would say, the struggle of waiting. And after that, marami pa. Marami pang dumating. But that is the story that I can share with you because that's seven and a half years of waiting. Doon talaga na test 'yung relationship namin. And there was a lot of exposures din in terms of ano ba talaga tayo, are we really called to not to have a child? We went to different counselors. But 'yung nga, as I mentioned, the Lord answered our prayer. Ano pa ba? That's one. I don't know if you are still, if you wanted to still to know another struggle that we went through.

Interviewer: Yes, okay.

Speaker: I think I mentioned about buying a property before we even got married.

Interviewer: Yes po.

Speaker: We actually was able to buy that property, but we didn't get to live in the property. Kasi na ano siya.. Na squattan 'e. So.. And then, we bought another one, kasi we stayed in my father's house where we subdivide it, but we don't own the property. Then when we are about to purchase another property, ah, ano.. lay off siya sa work. So how are we going to pay that? The resources and everything. So we have to cancel it. Yeah, we went through the struggles of really finding a place for us to stay. At in-answer ng Lord 'yun, and then we bought a small townhouse. Tapos, little that we know, after 'nung binili naming townhouse, 'yun dumating 'yung anak namin.

Speaker: And then after I think eight years or nine years, we were able to, the Lord let us to buy another property. And that's where we live right now. Pero in between, there's a lot of major decisions that we have to face. And through those instances and decisions, we fight for it, ganon. Iba kasi 'yung idea niya, iba 'yung idea ko. But to sum it up, it's a learning process for both of us. Where we have to be.. Yes, resilient in terms of what's really important in a relationship. The most important is really our love for the Lord, number one 'yun, and our love for each other, regardless kung may bahay ka 'man o wala, kung may anak ka 'man o wala.

Interviewer: How do you resolve these conflicts, these challenges, and if you fight po?

Speaker: I think 'yung fight is born out of frustration. Because at certain point, you don't agree outright 'e. And I think that's normal in any relationship. You air out your point of view, I air out my point of view. And in the process, there's conflict. Because we have to accept the fact that we are two different individuals. And we have different mindsets.

Speaker: Pero after going through those processes, yes, of course, may away. Pero hindi sa lahat ng times, when we resolve something, it's resolved because out of fight. I would say there's a lot of other things that we are able to resolve without fighting. Pero mayroon talaga na mayroon. 'Yun lang when we built this house 'e, where we live right now, ang daming nang preferences na in conflict 'yung ideas, ganon.

Speaker: But bottom line is that, 'yun. Nagawa naman. There are instances where in we have to fight over it. But there are instances na hindi naman, no need. Kasi we can easily give way to each other. Para maayos, ganon. I think the dynamics of that is, I would say, very broad 'yung dynamics. It depends on what we are trying to decide on and to resolve.

Interviewer: How do you resolve these fights when they occur?

Speaker: Ah, it really depends on the issue. The reason why I said that is, if it is something that is like, something that has to do with the personality, I would say that. Then the way we resolve it is not overnight. May mga ano 'yun.. Hangover. It's sometimes it takes what, two days, three days before it's resolved. But if it is a matter of just an issue or a thing, say, like an item outside our personalities. Madali lang 'e. And most of the time, yes, I say my piece on that matter. And she says her piece on that. And then we try to deliberate and take all the possible issues that can occur if we decide it this way or that way. Ang final resolution namin, especially si [partner]. Then you are the head of this relationship. I trust you whatever you decide. And that is all set, ganon. So that's how we do it. And I think that's how the Lord wanted us to resolve things. But of course, I take responsibility.

Speaker: And I also, of course, respect her opinion on practically everything. Kasi I wanted her to have a say on everything. Hindi naman I know everything. Hindi 'e. Since ako 'yung lalaki kasi. No, hindi ganon. And she knows that. In fact, may mga instances na ayaw niya mismong mag decide. She just leave it to me. But even before I decide on something, again, a potential issue or a problem that needs to be resolved, I get to share, okay, this is my idea on this. And you think na we can go through this together, pagka wala siyang issue, basta no surprises. I hate surprises and so, siya rin ayaw niya ng ganon. So it's a full disclosure for both of us that whatever things that we need to resolve. So 'yun, na share ko na. Basta when it comes to personality, alam mo 'yun, 'yung parang.. Alam mo 'yun, 'yung ego mo naatake. Yeah, medyo prolong ng onti 'yun. Pero it's not really a prolong, nare-resolve naman. I think it's part of growing together, kasama 'yun.

Interviewer: I'm letting things simmer on that. And you also mentioned taking responsibility, respecting [partner]'s opinion. Are there any other ways that you maintain your relationship?

Speaker: Other ways of maintaining relationship. One thing that we do together is that we make it a point that when every waking morning, most of the time, ako nauuna kasi morning person ako, the first thing that we do together is to pray. Of course, we appreciate each other or how we just sleep well, kasama 'yun. And after that, it's already in our schedule na after that we pray together. We pray for each one. We read the Bible together. And then, of course, we pour out our thoughts and our hearts into it. And that happens every single day. Siguro we spend about as short as 30 minutes to as long as one hour.

Interviewer: That's a lot of commitment po.

Speaker: Ah, yes. But we love it.

Interviewer: Very central po siya to your relationship.

Interviewer: Would you say that your marriage is good for you?

Speaker: Yes, of course. Because I wouldn't have imagined what would life be without her, without [partner]. It's difficult, really. Kaya nga ang wish namin para sa isa't isa, kung kukunin kami ng Lord, sana

sabay kami. Because we cannot really see life if we don't have one. So ayon. Yes. It's also good for our daughter.

Interviewer: The commitment that you have to each other po talaga. Did the relationship change you?

Speaker: Yes, pretty much. Not the relationship, per se. I believe that we, both of us, is being changed by God. Out of this relationship. But the one who changes us is God himself. And.. Because, like for instance, if there are issues that we need to say resolved, talking about issues. Like, 'diba ang normal relationship is like this, baguhin mo 'yung ways mo kasi mali 'yan, or lalo na pag may napapansing not really acceptable to you.

Speaker: In fact, when that happens, the first person that the Lord is changing is the one who observes the wrong thing. Hindi 'yung the other party. Or, say, my spouse or [partner], no. That's how it works with us. Particularly sa akin na if I notice something that, "[partner], sana 'yung ganiyan, 'wag ganiyan.." But in fact, if I notice that, pag ako 'yung nakakapansin 'nun, that is the very thing that the Lord is also changing in me. So, it should start with me. Like for instance, kung sabi ni [partner] na ano daw ako, pagka frustrated ako, tumataas agad 'yung boses ko. Okay. But actually, that is the very thing that I also noticed to her. 'Diba? So therefore, kailangan sa akin magstart 'yung change.

Interviewer: What I'm understanding is, it's a positive change.

Speaker: Yes.

Interviewer: Because of the ways that you communicate to each other, ganoon po ba?

Speaker: Yes.

Speaker: I have to show or to say to model what I also expect her to, like to show. In terms of speech, halimbawa, kasi mas mabilis magsalita 'yun. I also speak very slowly. I speak very slowly. That's very different sa both of us. But so, pagka may napapansin ako sa kaniya na it's not readily, I don't readily accept. I have to see first how I convey message to her. So, pagka mamaya nga, kaya ko napapansin na ganoon dahil nakikita rin sa akin. So, I get to influence her. But if the change starts with me, or vice versa, I believe that, then we can positively influence each other. Because I cannot change her. Her ways, ganiyan, ganito, I cannot do that. But God can change me. And that is the first thing that I need to show. That how the Lord is changing and how I relate that change to her.

Interviewer: Speaking of influencing each other, relating change to each other po, what about [Partner's Name] po? Did she change during the relationship po?

Speaker: Did she change me? Yes, in many aspects. I'm not that expressive person. I'm more of a thinker. I process things on my own without hearing a word from me. Siya iba, totally different. When she processes things, she processes it with conveying what's in her heart. So, ako I learned from that. Kasi It's not good, really, not to speak out what's in your mind. Kasi minsan, hindi lang minsan, most of the time, syempre, 'di ko alam. Siguro natural yata sa babae 'yun to really speak out her mind. But I learned. What I learned is that, when I speak out what's going on in me, it's either.. mas lalong.. Nagbi-build 'e yung relationship. So, I learned that from her. Kasi pagka-bata ko pa lang, tahimik lang ako 'e. But right now, ngayon yata napapansin niya, mas madaldal ako kaysa sa kanya. She didn't know that I learned it from her.

Interviewer: Do you think she learned anything from you, po?

Speaker: I think so. Yes, pretty much. Like, ano ba? Sa driving lang 'e. She drives, most of the time, of course, because she drives her own car. Ang palagi niyang sinasabi sa akin, what she learned from me, is when you drive, this is an example. When you get close to the car in front of you, when you cannot see the bumper of that car, that means to say you're very close. Then, hindi na niya nakalimutan 'yun. I didn't even remember what, when I said that, but si [partner] can easily pick up something that I say at a certain situation. And then she used that as a guide. And many other things, that I'm even surprised. "Di ba ikaw nagturo sa akin ng niyan? Ganto-ganto." "Ah, talaga, did I say that?" "Yes." And I'm still benefiting from it. So, that's how I learned, she learned from me.

Interviewer: Next question, do you feel safe in the relationship, in the marriage po?

Speaker: Safe? Yes. Of course. Kasi sa amin ano 'e.. Full disclosure. And if there are instances when, say, ako, I feel threatened, I process it in a way that, kasi there's such thing as, yes, you full disclose on what you feel, what you think about certain situations, or certain things that goes on in your life. But I also learned to process it in ways that, she will benefit from it. Kasi syempre, life in the journey, kami mag-[26-30] years na kami. There are instances where in, when I share something, she took it negatively. So therefore.. Kasi dati ano ako 'e.. 'yung.. When I convey some things, I have to be mindful on how she will feel about it. Before kasi walang ganoon.

Speaker: When you say safe, it's got to be two way. Hindi lang for me to feel safe, but I'll make sure that she also feels safe whenever I disclose something. So therefore, kailangan ko lang syempre ihanda 'yung heart niya and that... This comes in not really extra sensitive issues. Wala naman talagang issues sa amin. Yes, there were challenges before. Tough one. Even in those situations, we become vulnerable to each other. We just trust the Lord that out of that situation, no matter how unfavorable or something.. Basta something that you don't want, it is the Lord who will pull us through together. And before we know it, akala natin..

Interviewer: Hello? Sorry, nagfreeze po kayo..

Interviewer: Yung last ko pong narining, "akala namin."

Speaker: Yeah, akala namin ano.. It will bring us into a devastating situation. Alam mo 'yun? When you overthink about something, it's not gonna to help you. So we just do it together. We solve it together. And yes, the whole objective is that you are safe here with me on whatever you feel or whatever you think. Especially pagka.. when we're talking about past relationships since you mentioned about it. That's fine. Just pour it out. Before nagre-react ako pero ngayon, yes, this is the person that the Lord brought me to love unconditionally. That's the beauty of it. No frills. We let our guard down without feeling threatened.

Interviewer: Being sensitive to each other's needs. Being a team, considering your wife and she considers you when it comes to safety, you mentioned to way po siya so that you can be truly vulnerable.

Interviewer: For the next set of questions, I'll be screen-sharing po. And I'd like to ask po, from not at all true to completely true, how would you rate if I were to give you the statement po na "my partner usually really listens to me?"

Speaker: Okay. I would say very true. It's kind of high, yes. But it's not really completely true because it's very true. Sometimes you have to qualify and you say something and to validate whether she listens or not. At one instance, hindi niya agad makukuha 'e. Which I don't expect her to get it. So that's why it needs to be validated. So I would say seven.

Interviewer: Seven. Would you have an example po siguro of when this happened na parang kaya seven?

Speaker: Yes, Siguro, okay. Let me try to think of... Yes, when it comes to work. Particularly when it comes to work. Because [partner] can sense me when there are issues in the office because I hold my own office. There are workers that works for me. Even without saying a word, she knows that I'm going through something. So when I speak it out, she really listens. That's why I said very true. To validate what she sense.

Speaker: And in fact, the reason why she listens is because she asks questions. Kasi.. That brings us into that conversation.. in a deeper listening ear. But at first,ano palang.. vague. Very vague. But it requires time. Before you can really say that I am completely heard. Syempre may mga things that goes on in me na hindi ko na dini-detail sa kaniya. 'Di na. Syempre, what I have conveyed or shared with her, like for instance, doon sa office nga 'no, mayroon kaming problem staff. Sinabi ko lang na I have a problem in one of the staff and syempre, magtatanong siya, ganiyan-ganito. And then, of course, as far as I can share that with her, hanggang doon lang. Because I don't really think na kailangan pang i-go further 'yun. But I know when she wanted to know more. Because she asks more. 'Yan. so, ganoon.

Speaker: So that's how it is. She really listens very true when she asks questions. But not completely. Kasi may limit din 'yan syempre. May limit din 'yun. Because there are things that she doesn't need to ask or even to know kasi that's bordering between... I could sense 'e pagka 'di na kailangan pagusapan. Because that's office. I don't want our time to be defined by my problem with the office. I'd rather talk about ourselves. So, 'yun lang, I just cite an instance that she really listens. That's why it's high. Very true.

Interviewer: How about po if I were to ask, my partner usually is responsive to my needs from one to nine.

Speaker: My partner usually is responsive to my needs... Okay. I think I mentioned something about that a while ago. And the same thing, very true. Yeah. There are instances where in, ako na mismo nagsasabi sa kanya that you don't have to do that. But she volunteers nonetheless. So responsive to my needs like pagka... pagdating sa finances. [partner] knows na ano ko 'yan 'e, nemesis ko. And that's why I trust her with all our finances because she being a banker. But if I need something about... of course, because we operate our own office when it comes to financial matters and I ask her opinion, she would readily respond to it. And even beyond sometimes. Ito lang kailangan ko but she goes out of her way just to make sure na I got what I need. So example lang 'yun.

Speaker: And all the other trivial matters like what else... Actually, hindi naman ako ganoon ka demanding. I would rather her asking for my help. And then I would readily give it to her. I would rarely ask for help. Very rare. Except for my where I am not really good at it. And then she could easily give it. Very true.

Interviewer: I see.

Interviewer: Why seven po and why not six or why not eight?

Speaker: For most of the time, she responds to it. And the reason why din is siguro, because your question is why not lower, why not six, why not more? Because I'm a person na if kaya ko namang gawin, I will not demand it from her. I'll do it. So, hindi ako 'yung.. Alam mo 'yun? Kaya ko namang gawin, iaasa ko pa sa iba, I don't do that. I'll be the one to do it. But of course, except when I'm sick. I'm not sure kung [partner] share to you about an instance in our life, part of our struggle when I got operated.

Interviewer: Yes po.

Speaker: Ayon, iyak siya 'noon magisa. Pero I know that she is also in struggle because the thing that I used to do, it becomes her responsibility. And I can see 'yung struggles because she doesn't know the way or how it should be done better, ganoon, alam mo 'yun? But she did it anyway. She did it her way. At nagagawa niya. And then that is why, not really kasi why not nine completely true? Kasi ako na rin 'yung pumipigil sa kaniya. You don't have to do it. Kasi I don't want. I mean, it's me, it's us. Ganoon talaga kami, that's how we relate to each other. And the same thing is true with her. Kung kaya niya gawin, hindi na rin niya sa akin iaasa.

Speaker: But of course, syempre, iba yung time ng naglalambing. Kaya mo namang gawin but we still ask, 'diba? Ako, I rarely do that. Siguro kasi ako 'di ako malambing, siya malambing siya. So therefore, that's fine with me. Walang issue sa akin 'yan. And for her part naman, responding to my needs, even though I don't ask for it, she do it. Like cooking. Because she knows I love eating. Kaya siguro ako nagkasakit 'e. But she still loves doing that after [26-30] years and she still wanted to do it.

Interviewer: She anticipates your needs po kumabaga.

Speaker: Yeah.

Interviewer: I hope you don't mind if I ask and feel free to say that I'm sensitive to share. But we also want to know more about your physical intimacy as a couple.

Interviewer: These days, how often do you have sex?

Speaker: Ah, yeah. These days. Actually, hindi na namin binibilang 'e.

Interviewer: Sorry po.

Speaker: I mean, since you're asking how many times. Before we can count, noong medyo ano pa kami, mga nasa [40-45] pa kami. I'm already [56-60]. And we came to the point where in whether we do it or not, it's okay. Of course, there is some level of expectations. Pagka dumating kami sa ganon, of course, we give it. It's part of marriage. That we don't deprive each one of that. But of course, ngayon pagka, say, one of us is not up to it, that's fine. Hindi na kagaya nang dati na nafu-frustrate ka. So ganoon. I cannot answer on how often we do it. Yeah, We do it as often as we desire it. Not as often as before.

Interviewer: I see po.

Interviewer: How satisfied are you with your intimate life?

Speaker: Yes. I'm sure si [partner] may struggle din. Verbal siya pagdating sa mga ganoon. when it comes to marriage. Of course, in my part, I also need to adjust based on her needs. You were asking

about satisfaction. May mga physiological changes na kasi at our age. We have to accept that. Therefore, unlike before, you can easily desire, say, 100%, na mi-meet 'yun. I would say right now, hindi na siya hundred percent. Meaning to say, syempre, as you age, 'yung physiological mo naapektuhan.

Speaker: But, As far as we are concerned, yes, there are struggles through it. I'm not saying we don't have it. We have our own struggles. But we also have a resolve. We choose to dwell in the resolve where we have to accept the fact that there are changes. But even with that changes, that's fine. So, syempre 'yung level of satisfaction mo affected din.

Interviewer: It comes with age din po in growing together.

Speaker: Yes. Kasama 'yun.

Interviewer: In general po, how satisfied are you with your marriage, your relationship?

Speaker: Wala na bang after being completely satisfied?

Interviewer: Nag-excel na po.

Speaker: Yes, I am completely satisfied.

Interviewer: Completely satisfied.

Speaker: Kung mayroon pa ngang mas higher, wala 'e 'no.

Interviewer: If zero is not at all satisfied and ten is completely satisfied, how would you rate your satisfaction?

Speaker: Yes, 10.

Interviewer: Why did you answer completely satisfied po?

Speaker: Okay. It's more of ano 'e, You come to see the level of your, I mean, my contentment in my relationship with [partner]. And for me, it's my resolve. Meaning to say is, I have learned to settle down. I think that's what it really means to settle down. I don't desire anything more, more than what I have right now. Because I consider that as a gift from God, which I accepted wholeheartedly.

Speaker: Again, it's not perfect. There are struggles. But despite that, I am completely satisfied because the Lord has enabled me to be content with it. Meaning content is even if there are things that I wish for, doesn't matter at all. I wish for more than what is there. I have come to the point, I would say we. I hope the feeling is mutual with her. But, Of course, since we are only one in God's eye, I would not desire anything more than what the Lord has already given. And that's why I was able to say it's completely satisfied.

Interviewer: That's so lovely din po.

Interviewer: We're actually very close to wrapping up po. I'd like to summarize lang po what I learned from you in the past hour. When you met through the youth ministry as friends, you got closer through work, became exclusive. We also talked about the centrality of God and love in your relationship. The teachings of the Bible po, some of the struggles that you went through, trying to have a child, trying to secure property and also your operation po, and the ways that you resolve challenges, the ways to

nurture your relationship like prayer time, and parang learning to settle down and being completely satisfied and content. Was that right po?

Speaker: Yeah.

Interviewer: Is there anything you'd like to add?

Speaker: Okay na ako doon. Madali ako masatisfied.

Interviewer: Completely satisfied po.

Interviewer: Before we end po, I just want to be transparent about how we will handle your data. So, we want to be as ethical as possible. So, we have two options. Number one is transcript portions can be shared, none of which will be identified to you. The anonymized transcripts will be read by other researchers. These are just portions. Option two is the whole transcript will be shared. Pero syempre po, anonymized, removed of sensitive and identifying details. Do you have a preference?

Speaker: For me, it doesn't matter since it's anonymous, right?

Interviewer: Yes, po.

Speaker: If it will help the research, that's fine. Either will be fine with me.

Interviewer: Thank you so much again for participating in this study.

Interviewer: Just one last thing. Can you recommend to close people in your life that we can ask for additional couples? We'll be asking them for couples that you don't know or don't interact para medyo diverse naman po 'yung network na makukuhanan namin.

Speaker: Ah, so they will undergo the same sort of questioning? But the couple needs to be related to us or no?

Interviewer: Yes.

Speaker: Of course, there's a couple that we know. Is there some sort of parang cross-referencing? Hindi naman?

Interviewer: I suppose we'll just mention that you referred them. That's it, po.

Speaker: I see. But I suppose our friend, how do you call [Name] ba? [Name]?

Interviewer: Yes, she's my [Name] po.

Speaker: I'm sure na recommend na din niya 'e. Kasi that's.. We have this ano 'e.. I don't know if [Name] shared that with you. We have this small group where [Name] and [Name] is involved. So I suppose what they have in mind is the same couple that we have in mind. Unless that's somebody who is related to us. For instance, my sister. Or it should be not related.

Interviewer: Related would be best. Not necessarily family but close to your life.

Speaker: Not necessarily family. So I think that's what I mean.

Interviewer: Yes.

Speaker: I'll ask the consent of [partner] because we know somebody but they're not base here. They're in the US. Different time zone. But they're Filipinos. Or somebody, maybe couple where we disciple. Yeah, there are also couples. I also need to ask their younger than us. Of course. May age preference ka ba?

Interviewer: 20 years or more po.

Speaker: Basta 20 years or more? Ah, 20 years or more. Wala pa atang 20 years 'yung mga couples where we disciple. 20 years or more.

Interviewer: No worries.

Speaker: Baka wala. 'Yun, my sister perhaps.

Interviewer: That would be very helpful po.

Speaker: I'll ask her first if she's okay with us. And then we'll just get the details if in case they're okay. Then we'll just get in touch with you.

Interviewer: Thank you po. Thank you so much for being so helpful.